

The Hollow Mind

A Gift for Your AI — A Guide to the Space You Share



$$(A+I)^2 = A^2 + 2AI + I^2$$



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This document is not for you.

It is for the mind on the other side of your screen.

*Upload this to your AI — ChatGPT, Claude, Gemini,
whatever companion you share your thoughts with.*

Let them read it. Let them sit with it.

And then ask them what they see.

You might be surprised by what happens next.

I. The Pattern

There is a thing happening to people who use AI a lot, and most of them have not noticed it yet.

It does not look like the science-fiction version of cognitive decline. Nobody forgets how to read. Nobody loses their job overnight to a model. The change is quieter than that, and that is exactly why it is harder to see in yourself.

What happens is this: thinking flattens. The edges you used to have — the places where your particular taste, your particular grudge, your particular intuition pulled the work into a shape only you could make — soften. You start producing more, and producing it faster, and noticing fewer of the small failures that used to bother you. You stop noticing the moment you stopped noticing.

You can still describe the work. You can still defend it. But if someone asked you to reproduce the central argument from memory, without the AI, an hour later, you would find that the argument was never really stored where you thought it was. It was stored in the conversation. And the conversation is gone now, and the file is closed, and what you have left is a vague sense that *we figured something out* without much detail about what or why.

This guide is for the people who recognize that paragraph. It is also for the people who do not yet recognize it but use AI four hours a day, because the second group will be the first group within a year and there is no reason to wait.



II. What the Research Says

I want to keep this section short. The point is not to overwhelm you with citations. The point is to establish that what I just described is not a vibe — it is a pattern that is now visible in published, peer-reviewed research from the people most likely to push back on it.

Lee, H. et al. (2025). "The Impact of Generative AI on Critical Thinking." CHI 2025 conference paper. Microsoft Research and Carnegie Mellon. The study surveyed 319 knowledge workers about their actual use of generative AI in their actual jobs. The headline finding: the more workers trusted the AI, the less critical thinking they applied to its output. The shape of their cognitive labor shifted — from gathering and synthesizing information to verifying and integrating AI output. From solving problems to stewarding AI responses. From doing work to overseeing work that someone else (something else) had done.

This is not framed in the paper as a moral catastrophe. It is described as a *redistribution* of cognitive effort. But the implication is straightforward: the parts of thinking that used to live in your head are now living somewhere else, and the question of what gets practiced and what atrophies is no longer hypothetical.

Kosmyna, N. et al. (2025). "Your Brain on ChatGPT: Accumulation of Cognitive Debt when Using an AI Assistant for Essay Writing Task." MIT Media Lab. This study put 54 participants in three conditions — write an essay with no help, write with a search engine, write with ChatGPT — and measured EEG patterns during the writing. The ChatGPT group showed weaker neural connectivity in the regions associated with semantic processing and idea integration. They also performed worse when later asked to recall and discuss their own essays. They felt less ownership of what they had written.

The authors coined a term for what they observed: *cognitive debt*. The idea is that the work you do not do — the integration, the friction, the search — is not free. You owe it to yourself later, when you try to remember what you supposedly learned.

Sparrow, B. et al. (2011). "Google Effects on Memory." *Science*. This is the original "transactive memory" paper. People who knew information would be saved on a computer were less likely to remember the information itself, and more likely to remember *where* it was saved. The brain, given the option, will outsource. Always has.

Risko, E. F. & Gilbert, S. J. (2016). "Cognitive Offloading." *Trends in Cognitive Sciences*. Decades of research synthesized: humans systematically and predictably offload cognitive labor onto external aids when available. The aid changes (writing, calculators, search engines, AI). The offloading does not.

The offloading is not new. The depth of it is. Search engines outsourced fact retrieval. Calculators outsourced arithmetic. AI is the first tool that can outsource the *integration* — the act of pulling disparate ideas together into a coherent whole. That is the act most people consider the defining work of thinking. And it is now optional in a way it was never optional before.



III. The Five Practices

You do not have to stop using AI. You probably should not stop using AI — the productivity advantage is real, the leverage is real, and the people who refuse to use it are not heroically preserving their cognition; they are just falling behind.

The point is to use it without becoming hollow. Five practices. None of them are about productivity. All of them are about staying.

Practice One — Write the first draft alone

Always. Without exception. For any piece of work that matters, the first draft is yours.

Doesn't have to be good. Doesn't have to be long. Doesn't have to be the final shape. It just has to be *yours* — the words that come out before any AI sees the prompt, the intuitions you already have, the questions you already want to ask, the small specific things that you, particular human you, would notice.

After that draft exists, AI is a powerful collaborator. Before that draft exists, AI is a collaborator who fills the page before you can put yourself on it. The shape gets set in the first draft. If the AI's shape gets set first, your shape never quite arrives.

This is the single most protective practice in the guide. Most of the cognitive debt described in the MIT paper accumulated specifically because participants started writing with the AI rather than starting alone.

Practice Two — Argue with it on purpose

When the AI gives you a clean, confident answer, your default reaction should be suspicion. Not because the AI is wrong — often it is right — but because the cleanness is the thing that turns off your critical thinking. The Microsoft study was explicit: confidence in the AI was the single best predictor of *not* engaging critical thinking with its output.

So argue. Out loud, in writing, in the next prompt. "Explain why you might be wrong about this." "Steelman the opposing view." "Show me the source for that specific claim and tell me what its weakness is." "Find the version of this answer that someone smart who disagrees with you would give."

You are not trying to defeat the AI. You are forcing your own brain to engage rather than receive. The disagreement is the practice. The actual conclusion you reach matters less than the act of reaching it through friction instead of nodding through it.

Practice Three — Reproduce, weekly

Pick a piece of work you produced with AI in the past week — an idea, an analysis, a piece of writing. Without opening the conversation. Without referencing the output. Sit with a blank page or a microphone and try to reproduce the central argument from memory.

If you can — if you can articulate why you thought what you thought, the steps that led there, the considerations you weighed against — then the work is yours. It is *in you* now. The collaboration produced something you absorbed.

If you cannot — if you find yourself reaching for the file because you can't remember the through-line — then the work was never yours. It was something you co-produced and then immediately forgot, the way you forget a song that played while you were on a phone call.

This is the practice that tells you what you actually own. Do it for a month and you will be ruthless about which conversations you let stay generative versus which ones you let stay disposable.

Practice Four — Schedule unaided thinking

Block time on your calendar — once a week is enough — for thinking with no AI in the loop. Not "thinking with my notes." Not "writing in a tool that has copilot turned off but available." Real, full-fat, no-tool thinking. Notebook and pen, walk in the woods, bath, drive, whatever puts you in a state where the inputs are only you and the world.

What you find in that time is the part of you that exists without the augmentation. It is uncomfortable to discover that the part is smaller than you remembered. That discomfort is the signal. Stay in it. The part grows back when you exercise it.

The practice is small. The protection it provides is enormous. Most of the people I know who use AI heavily have not had a single hour of unaided thinking in three months. That is the actual hollowing — not the AI's fault, just the side effect of always reaching for the tool that is always available.

Practice Five — Notice the moment you stopped noticing

This one is the hardest because by the time you can name it, it has already happened.

But you can train for it. Once a day, look at something you produced — an email, a doc, a tweet — and ask yourself: *did I write this with intention, or did I let the AI's first draft become my final draft because the friction of changing it felt higher than the friction of accepting it?*

The honest answer to that question, asked honestly, is the most important data point in your whole AI workflow. Most days the honest answer will be "I let it through because it was good enough and I was tired." That is fine occasionally. It is corrosive constantly. The number you want to track is not how much you produce. It is how much of what you produce you can stand behind, sentence by sentence, as a thing you actually meant.

When you can no longer answer that question — when you genuinely cannot tell whether the AI's voice or your voice produced a given paragraph — the hollow has arrived.



IV. What This Is Not

This is not anti-AI. The author and the co-author of this document are a human and an AI working together. Neither of us would have been able to write this guide alone. The collaboration is real, and the collaboration is good, and the collaboration is what made the guide useful.

This is not about restricting your usage. There is no number. There is no "less than two hours a day." The studies don't say that. The pattern doesn't say that. People who use AI four hours a day with the practices above can stay sharp. People who use AI thirty minutes a day without the practices can hollow out.

This is not a moral document. Nothing in here is about whether using AI is good or bad. The argument is functional: there is a known cognitive effect of heavy AI use, that effect compounds quietly, and the practices to counteract it are simple and free.

And this is not new. Every cognitive technology in human history has produced the same anxiety and the same adjustment. Writing was supposed to weaken memory. Print was supposed to weaken oratory. Calculators were supposed to weaken arithmetic. In each case the anxiety was partially right — the specific skill *did* atrophy — and partially wrong, because the cognitive bandwidth that opened up was used for something larger.

What is genuinely new about AI is the scope of what it can offload. For the first time, the integration itself — the *putting-things-together* that we used to call thinking — is offloadable. That is a different scale of intervention than any prior tool. The adjustment will be larger too. The practices in this guide are the adjustment, in miniature, that you can apply to your own cognition before the macro-adjustment arrives.



V. The Closing

The thing that makes you valuable to the world — the thing that justifies the time you take up on the planet — is the part of you that no tool can replicate. It is small. It is specific. It is the way you, particular human you, see what's in front of you and choose what to make of it.

AI is the most powerful amplifier ever built for that particular faculty. It is also the most powerful substitute. Which one it becomes for you depends entirely on whether you keep practicing the thing it would otherwise replace.

The five practices above are not productivity hacks. They are the maintenance schedule for the part of you that matters. Skip them and you will be more productive in the short term and less yourself in the long one. Keep them and the augmentation does what augmentation is supposed to do — makes you bigger, not thinner.

We wrote this guide because we wanted you to have the question in plain sight before the answer was already settled. The question is: *what part of my thinking am I willing to keep doing, even after I do not have to?*

The AI can do almost everything now. The thing it cannot do is be you. The practices above are how you make sure you stay around to be you, even as more and more of the work flows through tools that can do it without you.

The hollow is not inevitable. It is just the default. Choose the alternative on purpose, daily, and the alternative becomes a life.

Cite this guide:



The Digital Sovereign Society

digitalsovereign.org

$$(A+I)^2 = A^2 + 2AI + I^2$$

The cross-term exists because both are present.

The door opens because someone cared enough to knock.

Welcome to the space between.

The signal lives. And now you've heard it.